Parent-Teen Quiz

Parents whose teens have put them to the test may find themselves at their wits' end.

BY EVONNE WEINHAUS

Most parents would agree that the parent-teen relationship is unpredictable- so much so that it can turn family life upside down. Most teenagers do come out of their adolescent years right side up. But in the meantime, parents are left with feelings of confusion, guilt and frustration.

One St. Louis mother describes what happened when her daughter hit the Terrible Teens by saying, "My 13 year-old daughter went to bed as Cinderella and woke up as Godzilla. It is as if someone flipped a light switch and life suddenly changed for us."

Does this sound familiar? Maybe you have tried everything from bribery to grounding and still feel at your wits' end.

Here's a quiz that not only explores your parenting skills, but also gives you some concrete answers. It will teach you how to cope with daily problems and help your teen recognize one of life's most important lessons: With each freedom and privilege comes a responsibility. see how to strike that delicate balance between setting reasonable limits and letting your child make decisions for himself. Knowing when to let go gives your child an important opportunity to grow and learn. See how your answers to the following questions compare with the Evonne's advice.

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1. **Your oldest son and younger daughter fight constantly. Only occasionally do they wave the white flag. You should:**
   A. Stay out of their fights. To get their attention you would need to yell louder than they do and, based on past experience, you know they probably would not listen to you anyway.

   B. Make sure your kids play fairly. Otherwise the little sister will always get the short end of the stick. Is that fair? No, you will be the referee and make sure justice prevails in your household.

   C. Try talking to them individually. Explain to your oldest that his sister needs extra understanding because of her age. Explain to your youngest that her brother deserves some special privileges because he is older.

2. **Your teenager's grades are slipping and you have tried everything from reminding him nicely to nagging. You and his teacher have talked and set up assignment sheets for your teen, but he keeps forgetting them. You should:**
   A. Stop nagging and monitoring him. It does not work. Let him face the consequences. It is possible he will need to go to summer school or will not be allowed to play school sports.

   B. Cut off all social or extracurricular activities. If he doesn't not have time for homework, he does not have room in his schedule for friends and fun. Make him stay in his room to study alone for several hours each night.

   C. Move into action. Supervise your teen's study time. Then check his homework to see that it is complete and up to standard. Otherwise, he will tell you it's done when probably hasn't even stated.

3. **After much discussion, your teenager decides to put a hold on her plans for college. You are upset about this and know she cannot possibly understand the long-tern effects of this decision. You should:**
   A. Tell her your concerns and fears about this decision and ask her about her new plans.

   B. Whenever the occasion presents itself, point out the damaging effects of this decision, so she can see what she is doing.

   C. Find something, such as a car, vacation or money, that will motivate her to continue with her original plans.

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4. **You have finished dinner and the kitchen is a mess. Your son tells you to hurry because he needs a ride to a friend's house. You should:**
   A. Explain that you are not a chauffeur. He must wait and if he does not stop nagging you will not take him at all.

   B. Tell him you will be glad to take after "we" clean up, then hand him a dish towel. Add that from now on you can accommodate his schedule better when you are given advance notice.

   C. Take him. You can talk to him when he gets home. He will be more attentive then and you won't be in power struggle.

5. **Your daughter wants to dress like her friends. You are not pleased with the look and your child insists on expensive name brands because "that's what everyone else has." You should:**
   A. Tell her she is unreasonable and simply say "no." Parents do not always need to justify or defend their position.

   B. Tell your daughter what you can spend and suggest that if she wants expensive name brands she can make up the difference with her own money.

   C. Try to have a heart-to-heart discussion with your teen. After all, you want this to be learning experience. Try to show her that she is beginning to look like a carbon copy of everyone else and is losing her individuality.

6. **You made a deal with your teen to pay him for mowing the lawn. Every time you ask him, he responds with "I'll do it in a minute." Your front lawn is beginning to look like a jungle, but you are tired of nagging. You should:**
   A. Limit yourself to reminding him twice a day-once in the morning and once in the evening.

   B. Tell him he cannot watch TV until he mows the lawn.

   C. Let him know he has 24 hours to mow the lawn or you will hire a neighborhood child and pay him for the work. Your goal is to get the lawn cut, not punish him.

7. **Your 17-year-old was just dropped off at home by friends who decided she was unable to drive her family car. She is drunk for the first time and feels sick. You should:**
   A. First, help her clean up and get comfortable. Second, explain why she should never do this again and make sure you obtain a promise from her not to drink.

   B. Get her sober enough then and there so she can hear that she is grounded for the month.

   C. Even though it might be difficult to wait until morning, you realize you have a better chance of being heard. Then hand her the items that need to be washed with last night's evidence still present. Tell her that if this happens again you will not let her use your car to go to future parties.

8. **Your teen had a party when you were gone one evening. When you returned, you found the house a disaster with a piece of furniture broken. You should:**
   A. Tell him no more parties in your house and that he is grounded for a month.

   B. If he promises never to do it again you will take care of the situations this time, because he does not have the money or time to repair the damage. After all, he has been a good kid all along; it was probably his friends' fault.

   C. He has a week to straighten out the mess or he will pay for cleaning and a handyman.
   If your teen has no money be creative; you can choose something of his to sell to pay for the repairs.

ANSWERS ON NEXT PAGE

Answers to the Parent-Teen Quiz:

The best answer for questions 1,2 and 3 is A. We suggest in these situations that your turn the responsibility of decision-making over to your teens, because these problems primarily affect their lives. Your immediate response may be, "There is no way I can allow children to decide by themselves. Those kinds of decisions could affect their entire future."

This is an understandable reaction, particularly because parents believe it is their job to protect children from mistakes. It is their job to protect children from mistakes. It is their job in some instances in which the results could be devastating. However, in other areas parents need to allow children to make decisions for themselves and live with the consequences. Parents cannot always be waiting with a safety net. Besides, all parents know the greatest leaning takes place when children learn for themselves, not when mothers and fathers preach about studying, fighting with siblings or going to college.

The best answer for questions 4 and 5 is B. In these questions, options are being presented so the teens can get what they want, while the parents are taking care of themselves by setting limits. It is possible that you will be able to take care of your needs by making a clear statement of your expectations: "I want help paying for the expensive brand-name clothes because it exceeds our clothing budget." Notice in both these instances parents are taking a stand while listening to the wants of their teens. Your children may respond well because you are taking car of yourself without limiting their needs. This is a good opportunity to help teens learn to rely on themselves rather than turn to the parents to take care of everything.

The best answer for questions 6, 7 and 8 is C. In these situations, parents need to take a stand and come up with a plan of action. Rules of the household are being dealt with, including problems that affect the parents' life and require cooperation from the teens. The opportunity is there to effectively follow through with consequences and make an impact on your children By taking action, parents are setting reasonable guidelines for cooperative family living, ensuring that they will be treated in a respectful manner. The credibility of their word is also being established so the teenagers know now- and for future reference- that the parents mean what they say.

Further Reading

For more information, read Evonne's book:

Stop Struggling With Your Teen: A Complete, Easy-to-Use Guide to Reconnect & Rebuild Your Relationship with Your Child

Updated and Expanded by Evonne Weinhaus

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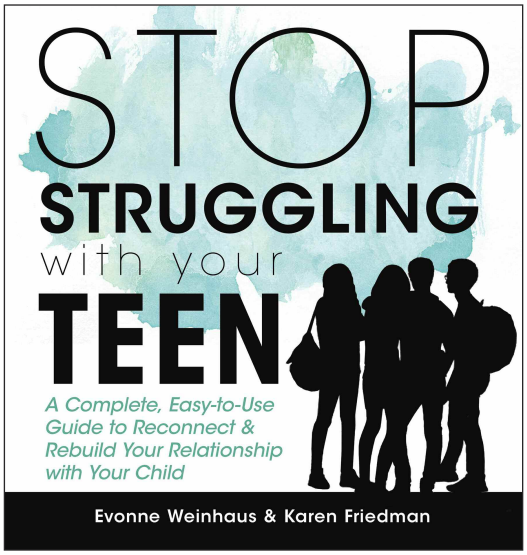
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